A common factor behind these guidelines is the importance of strengthening the 'writ of the state'. While there is a recognition that poor service delivery (defined here as education, health and water) has eroded the citizens' confidence in the state, the issue of law, order and control is nevertheless seen as the most important tenet in any reforms that will lead to a reduction in extremism. According to this document, the relevance of the state for the common person is in their day-to-day lives at the level of the 'revenue district' – 'the meeting point between state and citizens' considered to be the 'most important unit in State hierarchy' (NACTA 2018, p. 10). It is this weakness that is exploited by terrorist groups, where citizens become vulnerable to extremist ideology as the state fails to provide the most basic provisions to its citizens. The NCEPG document provides a holistic approach in strengthening this weakness, recognizing a trust deficit between the citizens and the state, which can primarily be addressed at the district level.

In building a 'national narrative' the NCEPG further focuses on dismantling the 'militant's narrative'. For this purpose, the strategy includes a 'victim humanization approach' that involves media outlets which will show victims and their families as the real heroes, projecting 'their human side and realness of their suffering and pain'. 'Justification of violence may be countered with reinforced, continuous and repetitive portrayal of the reality of victim's pain, their existence, loss to their families, humanness and innocence of the presumed enemy, futility of violence in achieving the desired political and ideological goals, isolation and marginalization, difficulty to legitimize the human costs etc' (NACTA 2018, p. 23). The strategy will also include a 'messenger' or 'change agent' who could be a 'former' terrorist or extremist who can 'expose the ugly side of violence since they have commonality with the terrorist and extremist' (NACTA 2018). The education system will be used to create a counternarrative that promotes a rich cultural history and identity of Pakistan. A key part seems a further reform of the education system including teacher training and curricular content, as well as madrassa reform and exchanges between schools and madrassas. However, the responsibility for this is left at the provincial level, making change at best a slow process, provided provincial authorities get on board with the new strategy.

While the NCEPG 2018 attempts to address the weak social contract between the citizen and the Pakistani state, the extent to which these guidelines will be implemented remains to be seen. In education, whether this realization will lead to an education strategy that would encourage critical skills is questionable. Higher education institutions are increasingly becoming spaces of surveillance, rather than of critical thinking. The case of the Hazara University in Mansehra